

Promising transition: 2025 signalled Qatar's emergence as a global hub for major sporting events beyond football. QATAR LOCAL ORGANISING COMMITTEE

events — not only in shooting, but also in disciplines such as Formula 1 and football. We are proud that shooting stands alongside these world-renowned competitions," ISSF president Luciano Rossi said. "Our strong relationship with Qatar is reflected in the fact that, in 2026, Doha will host the first Olympic quota allocation event for the Los Angeles 2028 Games, with the World Championships taking place in November."

Looking further ahead, Qatar is also set to host the 2027 Basketball World Cup, as announced by FIBA a couple of years ago, with the federation's president Hamane Niang admitting to being "impressed by the submission made by the Qatar Basketball Federation". The tournament will be held across four venues — Lusail Multipurpose Hall, Duhail Sports Hall, Ali Bin Hamad Al Attiyah Arena and Al Janoub Stadium. The Al Janoub, one of the venues for the 2022 FIFA World Cup, will be converted into a basketball arena, underlining Qatar's commitment to sustainability.

According to Jassim Abdulaziz Al Jassim, Chief Executive Officer of the Local Organising Committee for Football Events in Qatar, the "know-how" gained from hosting the FIFA World Cup three years ago enabled the country to stage the U-17 World Cup, Arab Cup and Intercontinental Cup in a span of just



two months. That experience appears to have encouraged Qatar's top brass to bid for multi-sport events. Doha, for instance, pipped Riyadh to secure the hosting rights for the 2030 Asian Games — the second time the city will stage the Asiad, having previously done so in 2006.

The ultimate test of Qatar's hosting ambitions, however, could come with the 2036 Olympic Games, should the country win the bid ahead of India. "It's a tough one. The Olympics are very big. Qatar wants to host it and we will bid for sure. India also has a great bidding plan that they are going with. But in the end, I think every country in the world has the right to bid and host," Jassim told reporters hours before the

Top draw: Paris Saint-Germain's Khvicha Kvaratskhelia (blue) in action against Flamengo during the FIFA Intercontinental Cup 2025 final at the Ahmad Bin Ali Stadium in Qatar. PSG won on penalties. GETTY IMAGES

Intercontinental Cup final. "I'm not really involved in the bidding process for 2036 but, like you said, I know that we have the infrastructure and the know-how. India also has a lot of good aspects and a lot of positive things that help them. May the best country win."

Hosting the Games during Qatar's punishing summer months is likely to be a point of contention. Still, as the Kirsty Coventry-led International Olympic Committee reassesses its host selection process, Qatar is pressing ahead with its packed sporting calendar. The country is set to host Argentina and Spain for the men's Finalissima, adding yet another feather to an already fast-filling cap.

The writer was in Qatar on an invitation by Qatar Local Organising Committee for 2025 FIFA events

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